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Chapter 15

Japanese Stone Gardens: Diversity, Sustainability, and Consumerism

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ABSTRACT

It has been suggested that the modern Japanese garden contains a wide variety of garden types. While some scholars have acknowledged the diversity of modern Japanese gardens, recent developments in Japanese stone gardens, known as karesansui, have gone largely unnoticed. Preconceived notions of karesansui do not encapsulate the true diversity which exists today. Moreover, the general public has tended to exoticize karesansui. Scholarly work on karesansui has, however, dispelled many of the myths and misrepresentations related to these gardens. In this chapter, the author will extend previous research and shed light on recent developments in karesansui and the myths that surround them. This chapter will examine karesansui from several perspectives: diversity, sustainability, and finally, from the perspective of consumerism.

INTRODUCTION

It has been suggested that the “modern Japanese garden contains a wide variety of garden types, from a 6.5 by 7 centimeter tabletop Zen gardening kit to large national park” (Watanabe, 2012, p. 340). While some scholars have acknowledged the diversity of modern Japanese gardens, recent developments in Japanese stone gardens, known as *karesansui*, have gone largely unnoticed. Preconceived notions of *karesansui* gardens do not encapsulate the true diversity which exists today.

Japanese gardens, including *karesansui*, have attracted a lot of attention from the general public, although, many generalist books have tended to exoticize the subject. In particular, the fascination with and romanticization of *karesansui* gardens has probably been the result of widespread interest in Japanese aesthetics, as well as the close association of *karesansui* gardens and Zen Buddhism, which has been glamorized in books such as Eugen Herrigel's, *Zen in the Art of Archery* (1978). Scholarly work on *karesansui* has, however, dispelled many of the myths and misrepresentations related to these gardens. For example, Yamada (2009) notes that Zen gardens were essentially reinvented during the post-war

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period as a strategic means of restoring Japan's international credibility. In fact, Yamada (2009) also closely scrutinized the association with *karesansui* and Zen and argues that *karesansui* gardens such as *Ryōanji* illustrate the “magic mirror effect”. That is, such gardens are a reflection of the ideal image of how Japanese people perceive themselves. In other words, Yamada views such gardens as symbolic of cultural nationalism.

In terms of modern designs of *karesansui* gardens, the work of *karesansui* garden designers such as Mirei Shigemori (1896—1975) and Shunmyō Masuno (1953—Present) has been well documented (See, for example Tschumi (2020); and Locher (2012), respectively). Given the immense popularity of these gardens, it is surprising that more recent developments in *karesansui* gardens have gone largely overlooked. However, as Girot (in Tschumi, 2020) notes, “we have ignored most developments in Japanese garden design over the past century” (p. 11). Indeed, this is particularly true in the case of *karesansui*.

In this chapter the author will seek to shed some light on recent developments in *karesansui* gardens by exploring different approaches to these gardens, and the motives which propel them. Contemporary *karesansui* gardens include a wide variety of garden designs, from avant-garde style *karesansui* gardens to digital *karesansui* gardens; from *karesansui* gardens designed with sustainability in mind to the adaptation of the easily recognizable patterns of *karesansui* gardens to a wide variety of consumer products. By examining some of the more recent developments in *karesansui* gardens, this chapter will show how more recent *karesansui* gardens overturn many preconceived ideas about these gardens.

This chapter will examine *karesansui* gardens from several perspectives: diversity, sustainability, and, finally, from the perspective of consumerism. This chapter is presented in three sections. The first section examines the history and characteristics of *karesansui*. Second, the development of new types of *karesansui* gardens are explored. Finally, *karesansui* are examined from the perspective of consumerism, and various modes of packaging *karesansui* for modern-day consumption are explored.

BACKGROUND

It is appropriate to begin with the most basic of all questions: What is a *karesansui* garden? The Oxford English dictionary defines a garden as, “a piece of ground, usually enclosed, where flowers, fruit, or vegetables are cultivated”. Clearly, *karesansui* gardens, which are mostly comprised of rocks, gravel or sand, do not fit neatly within this definition. In fact, *karesansui* gardens have a number of characteristics which make them different from other types of gardens, even other types of Japanese gardens. The term *karesansui*, which is commonly used to describe Japanese stone gardens provides us with some idea of the history and nature of these style of gardens.

The term *karesansui* (枯山水) is comprised of the Chinese characters *kare* (枯) from the verb *kareru* (枯れる), which is typically translated as “wither”, and *sansui* (山水), which comes from the Chinese term “*Shansui*”, originally pronounced “*senzui*”, and which literally means “mountain-water” but represents “nature” or “landscape” (Nakagawara, 2004). A term related to “*sansui*” is “*sansuiga*” (山水画), which refers to landscape paintings which were thought to have influenced the development of *karesansui*. An interesting discussion on *sansuiga* and their influence on *karesansui* can be found in Sekinishi (2006).

Rocks have been the objects of worship in a variety of cultures. In Japan, this has also been true, so much so that there is even a word for “rock worship” called *gansekisūhai* (岩石崇拜). The term *iwakura* (岩倉 or 磐座) is also used for specific rocks which are thought to have holy properties, and such rocks are often adorned by a *shimenawa* (しめ縄), a sacred type of rope. It is important to note that while

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separate to *karesansui* gardens, *suiseki* (水石), the art of stone appreciation, is a closely related art form. *Suiseki*, however, contrary to *karesansui* gardens, typically involves the displaying of a single rock in a similar manner to the way a *bonsai* plant is displayed. This respect and acknowledgement of rocks as elements of nature which possess a holy element suggests why *karesansui* gardens are not such an anomaly after all.

CHARACTERISTICS OF KARESANSUI

First, while many gardens are designed to be enjoyed by walking through them, *karesansui* gardens are enjoyed by viewing them from indoors, or from outside the garden itself. Ueda (1998), author of “The Inner Harmony of the Japanese House”, notes that gardens are something to be seen, and not a places to exercise or relax in. While it is not a completely foreign concept to not walk in a garden, this idea of a garden which cannot be walked in is particularly evident in *karesansui* gardens because the act of walking in the garden will upset the carefully raked stones effectively reducing or destroying the beauty of the garden.

Second, water is a principal feature of many types of gardens, including Japanese gardens. In fact, including water as a feature in a garden requires tremendous planning and work to supply the garden with water. On the other hand, *karesansui* gardens avoid this difficulty by not using water at all. In this sense, these types of gardens are very different from the popular pond-based style of garden known as *chisen teien* (池泉庭園).

Third, unlike other types of gardens where plants and vegetation grow naturally, gravel and materials used in *karesansui* gardens will not experience such changes (Koren, 2000). While the background scenery, referred to as *shakkei* (借景), of *karesansui* gardens is important, the impact of seasonal changes on *karesansui* gardens is much more subtle, and therefore they are sometimes thought of as all-season gardens. Finally, Koren (2000) makes the interesting point that, every time a sand/gravel garden is re-raked it is “anew, yet not really different from how it was before” (p.31). Koren (2000) further notes that there are no exact guides for the raking of *karesansui* gardens making them unique each time, and over time the gardens are raked by different people making it a type of communal creation.

THE HISTORICAL ORIGINS OF KARESANSUI

Historical accounts of *karesansui* frequently cite the Muromachi era (1336-1573) as the starting point. However, reference to stone placement in gardens in Japan’s seminal text on gardening *Sakuteiki* (作庭記), published in the latter part of the Heian era (794—1185), suggests that *karesansui* gardens were in existence much earlier (Matsumoto, 1980). *Sakuteiki* was a book of secret techniques for creating Japanese gardens and was only officially given its title in the Edo period (1603—1868), in which it was referred to as *senzaihisshō* (前栽秘抄). In the “Anonymous Secret Teachings” section of Takei and Keane’s translation of *Sakuteiki*, they provide the following translation of a section related to *karesansui*: “If there are stones that “flee,” then there should be stones that “chase” after; if there are stones that lean, then there should be those that lend support; if some proceed then other should acquiesce; if some face up, then others should face down; and to balance with stones that stand upright there should also be those that recline” (p. 183). This is significant from a historical perspective, because it provides evidence

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of the existence of *karesansui* gardens in the Heian era, despite many scholars treating *karesansui* as a phenomenon of the Muromachi period.

Nevertheless, the Muromachi era is significant and remains the period most closely associated with *karesansui*. It is true that one of the main reasons that gardening skills developed so much during the Muromachi period was because of the rise of gardening specialists known as *niwamono* (庭者) and *sansui kawaramono* (山水河原者). Note that *kawaramono* was a discriminatory term used for the class known as *eta* or *burakumin*.

Ashikaga Yoshimasa (足利義政) (1436—1490), the eighth shogun during the Muromachi period, was a lover of rare gardens. He was particularly fond of the gardening philosophy of Musō Kokushi (夢窓国師) as well as one of Musō's companions Zenami (善阿弥), a member of the *kawaramono* class who had a significant impact on gardening culture of the time. Musō Soseki (夢窓疎石) (1275—1351), also known as Musō Kokushi, was a Rinzai Buddhist monk gardener who was active between the latter part of the Kamakura period through till early Muromachi era. For more on Musō Soseki and his gardens, see: Davidson (2006). He designed several gardens in Zen temples, including gardens at *Tenryūji* (天龍寺) and *Eihōji* (永保寺) and is believed to be the creator of what is regarded as the first *karesansui* garden in Japan, the *saihōjikōinzan* (西芳寺洪隠山). Thus, Musō Soseki is frequently referred to as the “father of Zen gardens”.

In the Edo period (1604—1868), *karesansui* gardens spread beyond Zen Buddhist temples to a variety of different locations and residences of people from various classes, including the imperial Palace, samurai family residences, and townsfolk. The artist, tea ceremony master and garden designer, Kobori Enshū (小堀遠州) (1579—1647) is said to have contributed greatly to this spread of *karesansui* gardens during this period. Perhaps Kobori Enshū's greatest influence was on the Tea Ceremony in which his school was referred to as *Enshū ryū* (遠州流). It was during this period that *karesansui* gardens became more full scale in size, and, arguably, became more accepted by the general public.

The Meiji era (1868—1912) saw a decline in *karesansui* gardens. During this period, *Ueji ryū* (植治流) style gardens, which are a modern style of garden which emphasize the natural state of nature, became particularly popular during this time and continued through to the Shōwa period (1926—1989). While this period saw a decline in *karesansui* gardens, there was a revival of these gardens by the gardener Shigemori Mirei (1896-1975), who designed gardens such as the *karesansui* garden at *Tōfukuji* (東福寺). Shigemori strived to not only revive Japanese stone gardens but emphasized both the design of the garden as well as its conceptual elements.

Karesansui gardens are traditionally divided into two main categories: *zenkishiki* (前期式), which refers to *karesansui* gardens from the *Azuchimomoyama* period (安土桃山時代) (1573—1603); and, *kōkishiki* (後期式), which refers to *karesansui* gardens after that period. According to Miyamoto (1998), *zenshiki karesansui* gardens are constructed on the slope of a mountain, while *kōkishiki karesansui* gardens are constructed on the flat ground of temple premises. As we will see, however, these categories do not take into account more recent developments in design.

DIVERSITY OF KARESANSUI

Unfortunately, categorizing Japanese gardens does not encapsulate their true diversity. For example, Watanabe (2012) notes that public parks, many of which were daimyo gardens, are often neglected in discussions on Japanese gardens. Furthermore, Watanabe (2012) notes that there are many other types

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Figure 1. Photo of *karesansui* garden at Ryōanji in Kyoto, Japan

Source: From author's collection



of gardens which tend to be overlooked, such as Isamu Noguchi's gardens, which incorporate sculptures and sculptural elements, and Japanese colonial gardens in Asia. The purpose here is not to suggest that more recent *karesansui* gardens are better. What is abundantly clear, however, is that *karesansui* gardens are far more diverse than most people realize, and their ability to easily adapt to any environment may make them a more significant feature in future living spaces and art work. This is an important point and one that merits further elucidation through an exploration of some *karesansui* gardens.

Ryōanji

The most acclaimed *karesansui* garden in the world is the UNESCO world heritage listed garden, *Dai-unzan Ryōanji* (大雲山龍安寺) in Kyoto, which was established in 1450 by Hosokawa Katsumoto with the garden presumably being created around 1499. For most people, the image, as seen in Figure 1, is the image that first comes to mind when they think of *karesansui* gardens. It is representative of the quiet contemplative space that *karesansui* gardens have become so well known for.

However, there are a number of more modern style *karesansui* gardens that, while retaining some traditional elements, are distinctly different in appearance.

Kishiwada-jō teien

No discussion of contemporary *karesansui* gardens would be complete without considering the creative contributions of Mirei Shigemori (1896-1975). Shigemori was born in Yoshikawa in Okayama and studied painting at the Tokyo Fine Arts School. Shigemori was a prolific writer publishing on the history of *ikebana* as well as Japanese gardens and other topics. It was not until 1933 that Shigemori commenced designing gardens, and he is responsible for creating several gardens in the *karesansui* genre, including

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Figure 2. Photo of Kishiwada-jō Teien

Source: Adobe Stock



the garden at Kishiwada castle in Osaka (See Figure 2). His gardens have an avant-garde flavor that make them distinctly different from traditional *karesansui* gardens. He achieved this by adding graphic elements such as lines, planes of colors, or shapes and fonts (Tschumi, 2003). Tschumi (2003) argues that Shigemori was strongly influenced by the work of the Russian painter Wassily Kandinsky (1866—1944), particularly his book “Point and Line to Plane,” originally written in 1926.

Tschumi (2020), makes two significant observations about Shigemori. Firstly, Shigemori regarded garden design as art, and he was opposed to simply imitating past garden designs. Secondly, Shigemori believed that contemporary Japanese gardens lacked spirituality. His garden creations certainly seem to be consistent with this line of thinking. The *karesansui* garden at Kishiwada-jō in Osaka has fused elements of *karesansui* and modern art to create a modern looking *karesansui* garden. The sharp angles and straight lines of this garden are quite striking and are very different from *karesansui* gardens such as *Ryōanji*. The layout in this particular garden was inspired by the eight-fold battle camp strategic formation created by the Chinese strategy planner Zhuge Liang (181-234) from the Romance of the Three Kingdoms.

Canadian Embassy

Shunmyō Masuno (1953—Present) is an award-winning garden designer and Zen priest at Kenkōji temple in Yokohama city, Japan. He is a prolific author and designer having designed many gardens, including the dry landscape garden at the Canadian embassy (See Figure 3). According to Shunmyō Masuno’s website, he is “a modern-day Zen priest who through this art form, strives to express his spiritual self.”

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Figure 3. Photo of dry landscape garden at Canadian Embassy in Tokyo

Source: Photo courtesy of John Lander Photography



Once again, here is a *karesansui* style garden which is in contrast to what most people envisage when they think of *karesansui* gardens. The use of rocks in this particular garden represents the grandeur of the Canadian landscape. The main idea behind this design was to create a space for people who visit or work at the embassy to contemplate their roles in connecting Canada and Japan.

There have been further developments in *karesansui* gardens, and perhaps one of the more recent and interesting developments is how *karesansui* gardens are being designed with sustainability in mind.

SUSTAINABILITY AND KARESANSUI

Given the ongoing fears of global warming and environmental degradation, as well as increased interest in creating sustainable living spaces, it is perhaps unsurprising that some recent developments in *karesansui* gardens have been motivated or influenced in some way by sustainable landscape design.

Sustainable landscape design strategies are becoming an important part of urban landscapes and many of the characteristics of *karesansui* gardens are compatible with the principles of sustainability. A sustainable garden is designed to be both attractive and in harmony with the environment.

Many of the features of *karesansui* gardens which are compatible with sustainability are self-evident. Perhaps the most obvious characteristic is that *karesansui* gardens conserve water. Moreover, they require very little maintenance. Gardens by their very nature change over time. Therefore, old gardens do not maintain their form over time. In the case of *karesansui* gardens, however, they do maintain their form to a much greater extent. Mental health has been included in the UN Sustainable Development Goals

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(SDGs), and as *karesansui* gardens promote reflection and introspection, it could be argued that they are beneficial to mental health.

Vancouver International Airport

One recent example of a *karesansui* garden being motivated by sustainability is in Canada. The Vancouver Japanese Garden Association is building a *karesansui* garden at the West exit of the Vancouver International Airport. An article regarding this garden be found in the Vancouver *Shinpo*. The article discusses the difficulties associated with building a pond in a garden. For example, to create an artificial pond generally requires electricity to power a pump and may require chemicals to keep the water clean making it detrimental to the environment. On the other hand, a *karesansui* garden uses stones and sand to simulate the effect of water, making them much kinder to the environment. The article also mentions some other advantages, such as the low cost.

Nishinaka Glass Karesansui

Another example, and one which incorporates the use of recycled glass, is the glass *karesansui* garden “Eternal Affinity” (referred to as *Tsunagaru* in Japanese) at the entrance to the Honen-in Temple (法然院) in Kyoto, and created by the glass artist Nishinaka Yukito (西中千人) (1964—Present). Nishinaka has been influenced by *kintsugi* (金継ぎ) and *yobitsugi* (呼継ぎ) pottery work and adopted a similar approach to his glass work. He took this passion for glass and applied it to *karesansui* gardens. While sunlight on rocks used in *karesansui* gardens causes the rocks to glow and cast shadows, sunlight penetrates glass creating a very different effect. Nishinaka uses recycled glass in which remnants of the original piece of glass from bottles and so forth remain and are noticeable.

Another advantage of *karesansui* gardens is that they present an opportunity to engage with visual culture on a daily basis. Gardens function to sustain us aesthetically, but most of us do not have the good fortune to visit popular *karesansui* gardens on a regular basis. However, *karesansui* gardens can be made more accessible by incorporating them into our everyday environment. The author’s interest in *karesansui* gardens from the perspective of everyday aesthetics has been influenced by the work of Saitō Yuriko, who defines everyday aesthetics as, aesthetics of objects, environments, and situations from our everyday life.

Entrance (Genkan)

While it is generally accepted that an aesthetic experience can be had with almost any object, discussions on aesthetics tend to focus on art. For example, in the case of *karesansui* gardens, gardens like *Ryōanji* are regarded as quintessential dry landscape gardens, and discussions of aesthetics tend to focus on them. However, it is possible for people even living in Japan to never visit *Ryōanji* or any of the other eminent *karesansui* gardens. As Victor Papanek said, “it is possible to avoid theatre and ballet, never to visit museums or galleries, to spurn poetry and literature and to switch off radio concerts. Buildings, settlements and the daily tools of living however, form a web of visual impressions that are inescapable” (Papanek, 1995, p.174).

The practical nature of *karesansui* gardens as well as their compatibility with sustainable design makes them particularly suitable for our everyday environment, and it could be argued that this can cre-

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Figure 4. Photo of the glass karesansui garden Tsunagaru by Nishinaka Yukito

Source: Photo courtesy of Nishinaka Yukito



ate an aesthetic experience. Duncum exclaimed that, “ordinary everyday aesthetic experiences are more significant than experiences of high art in forming and informing one’s identity and view of the world beyond personal experience” (Duncum, 1999, p. 246).

Once again, Nishinaka pushes boundaries with his glass *karesansui* garden, which has been used as an entrance (*genkan*) to a living space. It is arguably a symbiosis of contemporary and traditional garden design, and one which is a visible demonstration of the new as a tangible realization of innovation and change, while remaining representative of the past.

CONSUMERISM AND KARESANSUI

The distinct and iconic patterns used in *karesansui* gardens are immediately recognizable and identifiable as symbolic of traditional Japanese culture. Therefore, the popular swirls and patterns of *karesansui* gardens have been incorporated into a number of consumer products, including jigsaw puzzles, games, confectionary, and even desserts. Indeed, there are a number of consumer items which have been produced for that purpose. For example, miniature *karesansui* kits, which allow people to make small *karesansui* gardens and can be used as ornamentation, are available for purchase. These miniature kits can also be purchased in “capsules” from popular children’s *gacha gacha* gift-dispensing machines. The close association between *karesansui* gardens and traditional Japan means that the *karesansui* patterns can be easily used to create a sense of “Japaneseness”, which may be useful in marketing products to both domestic and foreign markets.

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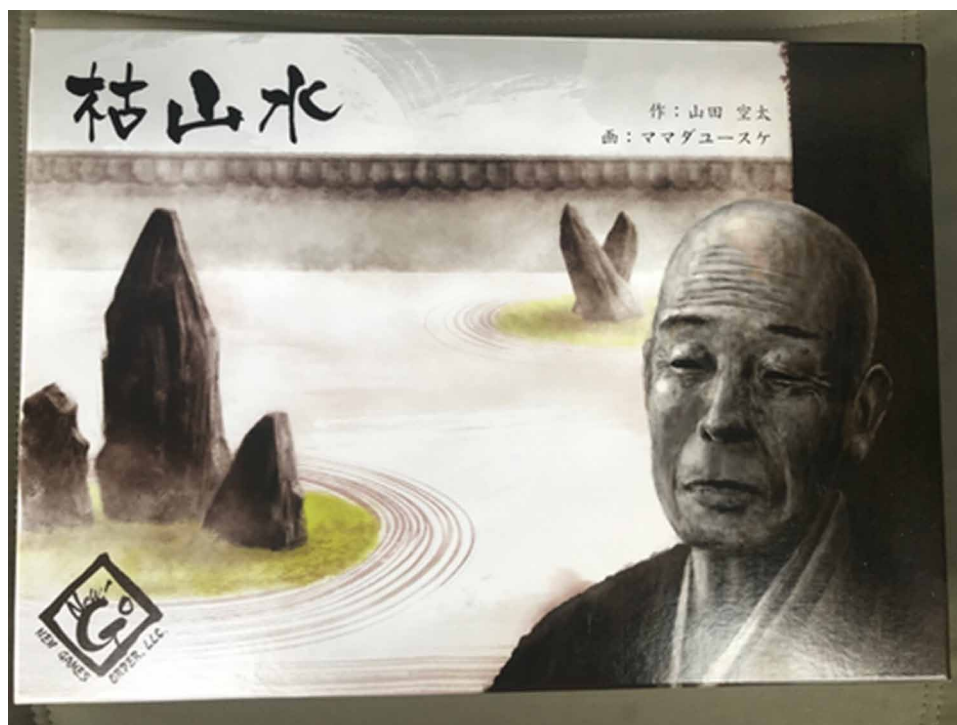
Figure 5. Photo of Nishinaka's glass Karesansui garden entrance

Source: Photo courtesy of Nishinaka Yukito



One interesting way in which *karesansui* has been packaged for consumers is in the form of a board-game (See Figure 6). The *karesansui* boardgame is simply titled “枯山水”(karesansui) and was released in 2014 by the company New Games Order, LLC, and is the creation of the boardgame designer Yamada Kūta (山田空太). Japanese and English language versions of the game are available. The board game includes individual boards, which are used to create individual *karesansui* gardens; cards with different patterns of raked gravel and moss; cards with important historical figures related to *karesansui*, including *karesansui* garden designers Shigemori Mirei and Musō Soseki, and which can be used to acquire special privileges in the game; and, five different types of rocks which can be used to place on top of the cards to create their own *karesansui* gardens. The object of the game is to create the best *karesansui* garden by scoring the most points. There are several rules in relation to how one can acquire points. The release of new editions of this game and the difficulty of purchasing secondhand versions of the game suggests that the game is quite popular.

Why is this important? Is it another example of what Yamada termed the “magic mirror”? Is it a way for Japanese people to reaffirm their sense of identity? In what way does eating a dessert with a

Japanese Stone Gardens*Figure 6. Photo of karesansui boardgame**Source: From author's collection*

pattern resembling something from a *karesansui* garden elevate the consumer's experience, particularly when this apparently has no impact on the taste. Is it in times of gastronomic bliss such as this when a Japanese consumer reaffirms to themselves that, *nihonjin ni umarete yokatta*. Literally, "I am glad I was born Japanese". It would be difficult to not concede that there is an element of that here, and one that savvy marketers are unashamedly exploiting.

As Cunningham (2016) acknowledged, *karesansui* gardens will have different meanings to different people. While the narrative which these gardens are built on has an unmistakable element of cultural nationalism, and one that scholarly criticism has aptly revealed, the multitude of forms in which these gardens appear suggests that they will continue to survive. Indeed, for the observer of *karesansui* gardens, in their many forms, these gardens may conjure up a feeling of nostalgic sentimentalism, reaffirm one's sense of cultural heritage, or simply provide a break from the grind of daily life. What is apparent is that, regardless of the various forms these gardens take and individual observer's experiences, these gardens are here to stay.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, recent developments in *karesansui* gardens have been explored. Clearly, long-held pre-conceived notions of *karesansui* gardens no longer accurately depict the true diversity of these gardens. *Karesansui* gardens today are taking on greater meaning as they fit ideally within the context of sus-

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tainability, and present opportunities to utilize this form of garden as a practical means to engage with visual art in our everyday life.

This chapter contributes to our knowledge of these gardens and extends existing scholarship which questions previous attempts to categorize Japanese gardens. While traditional style *karesansui* gardens will no doubt continue to function as tourist destinations and glimpses into traditional Japanese culture, and while new approaches to these gardens may not reach similar heights of popularity as gardens such as at *Ryōanji*, these gardens will inevitably continue to evolve and appear in various forms in the future. That is to say, they will continue to function as a creative force in our society, and recent developments will continue to push the boundaries of garden design and create exciting possibilities for future living spaces.

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